The Small Room

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Dog Door

CH17701-01

Dog Door

Ring Road

Admirer I: Sad news indeed. Ah, most unfortunate and disappointing news!

Stamping his feet in anger, the gentleman lets out a wail of frustration.

Admirer I: They canceled her new show, just like that? I've been waiting for it all season!

Admirer II: What else could be done? Surely you wouldn't expect her to sing after what happened?

Admirer II: Have some compassion for her, will you? Fate has dealt her a cruel hand in life ...

Although this lady immediately volleys criticism, there is nothing accusatory in the softness of her tone.

Admirer III: Vienna has lost its star, at least for this season.

Another man joins the conversation. Also terribly hit by the news, his eyes are as dim and cold as two lifeless cobblestones at the bottom of a river.

He walks at the rear of the crowd with heavy footsteps.

Admirer III: I ... saw it with my own eyes. The entire thing.

Admirer III: She left the Vienna State Opera in the afternoon. She must have planned to take a walk in Weigl's Dreher Park, as she always does on Thursday afternoons.

Admirer III: On that day, her dark, curly hair cascaded over her shoulders, and her face was pale as porcelain.

Admirer III: She was in a lavender dress with a soft wool shawl around her arms. She looked pretty and fragile, like a doll made of glass.

Admirer II: Did you see her—

Admirer III: Yes, I saw her faint.

Admirer III: She seemed perfectly fine when she took leave of the theater manager. But after a few steps, she started shaking ...

Admirer III: She whimpered and scratched at her pretty face. Her usual heavenly voice became the howling cry of a mad cat.

He murmurs with a dark heat in his tone. A light of sinister delight flickers in his eyes.

Admirer III: Her servants tried to stop her, but it was too late! She ran off, tripped over her dress, and —and fell down the Albertina stairs! They helped her up, but by then, she'd already fainted.

Admirer II: God in Heaven! Poor thing!

His audience responds with gasps and sobs.

Admirer III: It breaks one's heart to see such a thing. Soon, her physician came. He'd been by her side all day. It was only in the brief moment in which that horrid affair occurred that he was away attending to another matter.

Admirer II: Did he take her to the hospital? How is she now?

Admirer II: Oh, heavens, this is terribly sad. Most unfortunate for a talented lady such as her ...

Admirer II: She's so delicate. Even a strong gust of wind could whisk her off her feet. And now she has to come to terms with the painful fact ...

Admirer II: ... that her dear child has been cruelly taken from her ...

The lady whips open her mother-of-pearl fan to hide the tears that are now streaming down her face.

Admirer II: Thank goodness, she still has Theophil. Still, it does little to ease a mother's pain ...

She continues to mutter to herself. Though her cheeks are still wet with the tears of compassion, there is a quiet joy in her heart as she attracts the others' gaze.

Admirer II: None of us—none of us would ever have the courage to face such tragedy ...

Admirer II: Having to witness her own child taken by death at the seance three days ago must have destroyed her ... We were all there, you know, Lili Marlene, Fiona and I. That poor girl. Such a lovely little thing.

Admirer II: Little Trista. She was only three years old ...

Admirer II: Her rosy cheeks turned a grayish-blue within seconds. Her pale lips were stained red with blood, and two golden tears welled in her empty eyes and ran down her cheeks. She died in a moment ... just like that.

Admirer II: But that sweet song didn't fade away. For the whole night, it was trapped in her throat, like a little songbird captive in a cage ...

Admirer II: It wasn't until morning that we mustered enough strength to touch her. She was still soft ... as if she were only sleeping ...

She gently flutters her fan as she reveals more and more details to the crowd. They listen in breathless suspense.

Admirer I: I ... I didn't know that.

Admirer I: Fine, I admit it! I was too harsh on her. No one would be able to sing on stage in the wake of such misfortune!

Admirer I: She should rest. She must be devastated, poor thing, losing her child like that.

The gentleman takes out his silk handkerchief and dabs at the corner of his moistened eyes. This is a situation in which sympathy is the only appropriate response.

But a voice from the other side of the crowd breaks the sad silence.

Admirer III: No, she didn't cancel the performance to mourn her daughter!

Admirer III: Did you forget? She showed up at the rehearsals after her daughter's death. I saw her just yesterday!

His face reddens with frustration at these speculations.

Admirer III: Her doctor came to me that very night with a dissected rabbit in his palms. A quick look made it very clear.

His eyes are red and bulging, just like the pair of distended ovaries he saw inside the rabbit.

Admirer III: She is with child again—two months into her pregnancy, in fact! The announcement of a new child just three days after her daughter's tragic death!

Admirer III: The change in the rabbit's ovaries told us everything. I wish I could show you, good people, for it is evidence most irrefutable!

Admirer III: Evangeline must rest, no matter how much she loves the stage and her audience. She has no choice!

Admirer III: **She. Has. No. Choice!**

???: That was her first appearance in Vienna.

???: A fanatic admirer bribed her mother's doctor, subsequently discovering her existence through a fluffy—and oddly bloody—pregnancy test.

???: Perhaps soon these rabbit tests will become a mainstream method of determining pregnancy.

???: Haha ... Who knows what will happen in this world of turmoil?

Someone approaches from behind. The figure of a child.

???: Favored by the god of theater, this child is a star—even from before birth.

???: In the many years that followed, before she made her debut, people talked of her as "the girl who arrived upon the wings of death."

???: But is she really an opera singer?

The voice pauses, awaiting an answer.

???: Look at her. Isolde, my lovely little sister. She's the new star of Vienna, gaining both fame and fortune in the theater.

???: As a singer, her name has surpassed that of our mother, who is now only remembered as the perpetrator of that appalling crime.

???: But my sister has never performed in a play. Not even once.

???: **She's there, but she also isn't.** She's many people, including me—my voice in her throat, my smile on her face ...

???: Upon the stage, many spirits wander.

???: There are men's voices, women's voices, even children's—you can find them all. Different songs, different stories ... But they aren't hers.

???: Yes, yes ... rather innovative, isn't it? To channel spirits in an operatic performance.

???: Emotions she has never felt gleam in her eyes and flow from her mouth. She holds the spirits as they gently fall upon her, just as she is held by the stage.

???: Yes, silly goose. My little sister was never an actress. She's but a stage upon a stage—a pretty glass vessel!

A little hand softly touches your shoulder, and the other points into the darkness.

???: Now, look over there.

???: A door? Hmm, why's there a door? How strange!

???: Am I right? Did I guess what you were thinking?

The figure bursts into delighted laughter.

???: We all know what a stage looks like. There are no walls, but there are doors.

???: No, not the entrance doors to the theater. I'm talking about the doors behind the wings—the hidden ones that lead backstage.

The hand raps on the door.

???: This is the first door.

???: A narrow doggie door sitting an inch above the floor, painted in a calming blue. Who uses it, I wonder?

???: Could it be a Border Terrier? At a well-proportioned 6 kilograms, it would fit through the door perfectly.

???: It would be rather pleasant to keep around. A little angel in the home, a loyal and energetic friend, whose little paws softly tap across the marble floor.

???: But no ... The door isn't made for a little Scottish hill dweller.

???: Their feet get muddy, their fur dirty, and they have the pitiful little faces of a beggar.

???: No, they don't fit in at all in this spotless home. Those who live here must be presentable and praiseworthy, with manners learned from the most esteemed of teachers.

The terriers sprint past you as they chase one another, a flurry of wind rushing by your left calf.

Something taller, heavier, and calmer emerges from the dark. A warm breath settles on the skin of your right calf.

???: Ah, very good. A Leonberger. They were the stalwart friends of our honorable Sisi, the Empress of Austria. People were once madly in love with them.

???: It has a soft black and brown coat, a posture reminiscent of a lion, an intelligent mind, and a kind heart. Most importantly, this is an expensive breed. It's quite an excellent reflection of its owner's wealth and refined taste.

???: It weighs 115 pounds, a good boy with a sturdy build. It's 28 inches at withers, and a trustworthy protector of your wife and children ...

The voice disappears again, along with the warm breath.

The majestic dog raises its hundred-pound body and dissolves in the shadows.

???: But it's much too big to fit through this door ... No, this can't be it.

The girl lets out a regretful sigh, followed by a bracing breath. Her face is barely visible in the dark, but somehow you know she is smiling.

???: You see, this is my door. I fit through it perfectly.

???: It wasn't always exclusively mine. There were other people—people who were of the right size and met the other conditions for its use.

???: But time is cruel. It turned Theophil and Isolde into adults, taking them out of their little five-year-old bodies and replacing them with new ones with bigger hands and feet. Now, I alone can pass through this little door.

???: Every Dittarsdorf child knows how to use this door. Just lower your head, bend down, and crawl through it.

Trista: Since I'm the only one using it these days, I have a new name for it—"The Door of Trista the Forgotten."

The little hands lying on your shoulders give a gentle push. The doggie door squeaks open. It is much easier to pass through than you had imagined.

Bedroom

Evangeline: Hush, my baby, dry your tears; the cradle's safe and warm ...

Trista: Ah, Evangeline is here. The source of the sweet humming. Our mama. We all once lived inside her.

Trista: She always rocked this cradle with her left hand. It's the same one that Theophil, I, and our little sister, Isolde, all used.

Trista: ...

Trista: She's singing her a lullaby.

Trista: But her performance is rather clumsy. It's a new song, a birth gift to Isolde from the playwright. He wrote one for each of us when we were born.

Evangeline: She's asleep ... Thank goodness. She cries so much, always trembling as if something's frightened her ...

The mother sighs as she sits by the bed.

Evangeline: Mother said I was the same way when I was a baby. Perhaps it's a family trait passed down from girl to girl?

She thinks to herself, running her fingers along the edge of the cradle. As soon as the word "curse" comes to mind, she feels the tip of her finger touch something: a dent in the wood left there by her second child.

Evangeline: No ... Trista didn't like to cry. She giggled a lot—even looking at the empty ceiling or the lamp stand.

Evangeline: She was never frightened—nothing could scare her. She'd cackle at anything, as if they were jesters, and she the queen ...

Trista: She still remembered me, even then. She's a good mama.

Trista holds her mother from behind, nestling her head in the crook of her mother's neck.

Trista: She was immature in the past. She wouldn't have taken me to the seance and made me the medium had she known any better.

Trista: But she learned her lesson. Truly. After my death, she never sang my lullaby again.

Trista: As I was lowered into my little grave, that song buried itself in her throat.

Trista: But was that enough?

Trista reaches out an arm and gently strokes the cheek of the baby in the cradle. The cold chill of her hand wakes her.

Trista: It was only a song.

Isolde: *whimpers*

Trista: Oh, Isolde. You stupid little girl. Always crying.

Evangeline: My, she's shaking again. Her face is so cold ...

Trista: However you look at it, my failure laid the groundwork for Isolde's success.

Trista: ... Perhaps you don't think she's successful.

Trista: But at least she didn't turn into a little lump of dead meat at the age of three. For a Dittarsdorf daughter, that's quite an achievement.

Trista: I'm very fond of my little sister. I love her. I sang her the buried lullaby—my lullaby. I laid beside her on those crying nights and trembling mornings. I crawled with her, and I walked with her.

Trista: Sometimes I think about how I could have grown up as she did. What a pity that I'm six feet under the earth, while she walks upon it.

Trista: She soon turned three. But the seance didn't happen.

Trista: As I have told you, my mother, my Evangeline, had learned her lesson. She knew better by then.

Trista: *chuckles*

Trista: She continued to put off my little sister's first seance for many years. She was six by the time she was led into the candlelight.

Seance

Isolde: This is ... is ...

Noble Lady I: Tell us, child—what do you see?

The candle light flickers in the dark room. The lady asking the question leans forward in eagerness, the light reflected in her eyes.

Isolde: Mmm ...

Noble Lady I: Speak, good child. The spirit has come to us—it has come to you!

Noble Lady I: I need an answer. I've waited so long for this, child. I've heard all about your gifts ...

She has waited three years—much too long for someone whose insides twist with anxiety over the future.

Isolde takes a deep breath, letting it out slowly.

Isolde: Urhh ... Hah ... Urmmm ...

Noble Lady II: Is she alright? She's ... shaking.

Noble Lady II: Evangeline never shook like this ...
She looks just like her sister did ... What has she called forth?!

Noble Lady I: What's happening? Does my future hold so dreadful a spirit? I just wanted to know where I'd be in a few years ...

Isolde: Urgh ...!

Noble Lady II: Good lord, she's bleeding!

Isolde trembles, her back stiff. Her hands tightly press against her chest, move down onto her stomach, and eventually stop at her lower abdomen.

She whimpers in agony. Her knees quiver until she can stand no longer and collapses to the floor.

Evangeline: The candlelight. It's flickering ... She did it!

Isolde: I ... see ...

Her pale arm writhes under her sleeve like a thin, white snake. It lifts its head, its red tongue flicking towards the lady.

Isolde: I see you ... in a sea of green ... horses are neighing ... wind is blowing ...

Isolde: ... the wind is ... the wind ...

Red drips from her nose and down onto her chest, blending into the whirls of dark colors on her dress. The air is filled with the metallic smell of blood.

Isolde: The wind is blowing and blowing. Yes, it came in from the window.

Isolde: Hah! That's right! It's wind! I see it now! It's the wind ... It's the curtains, the curtains!

Isolde abruptly lifts her upper body and starts rhythmically slapping her bloody palms against the floor.

Noble Lady II: Aaah!

Noble Sir I: Hell! What's that sound?!

The windows are thrown open. An icy wind rushes into the room, immediately extinguishing the candles.

Evangeline: Wind? How?! We locked the window!

Evangeline: Something's wrong. She's getting out of control! Isolde ...!

Everyone leaps to their feet, scrambling to reach the door first. Amidst the chaos, the young girl stands up.

Evangeline: Isolde, stay calm! Isolde!

To her, the calls of her mother sound like echos from a faraway place.

Isolde simply drops her head and gently nibbles at her nails.

Isolde: Close the window ...

She mumbles, her bloody lips opening and closing gently.

Then, they open wide. She cackles with delight before screaming in a voice that is not entirely her own.

Isolde: Close the window! Close the window! Close the window!!!

Trista: After that, my little sister passed out. Her first seance ended in disarray.

Trista: People were scared. They didn't believe her to be a capable medium ... You would've thought the same had you seen her blood-spattered gown.

Trista: The successive failures of me and my sister completely shattered the curiosity over these seances. People started to believe that our ability to channel the spirits had become too strong to control, and that the practice was somewhat "evil."

Trista: For some time, the people of Vienna lost all interest in the seances, and consequently, Mama was snubbed.

Trista: But this didn't last long.

The girl offers a gentle smile as she tucks her curly hair behind her ear.

Trista: Annette Mayer, who spent the rest of her life afraid of the color green because of the prophecy brought forth through my sister, met her end.

Trista: She died on the street. A frightened horse charged towards her. It was wearing a green saddle blanket on its back and a shining green gem on its forehead.

Trista: Green, more green! Ms. Mayer was utterly terrified.

Trista: She screamed, and, as she dove to the side to dodge the approaching horse, she stumbled over a step and fell into a roadside bush. A sharp branch pierced her chest.

She draws a small circle on her chest, marking the location of the wound.

Trista: Ha ... Eerie, isn't it?

Trista: All of Vienna was wholly convinced. The prophecy was true. Once again, they gathered around Mama and my little sister, like ants reporting to their queen.

Trista: Oh, of course, little Isolde lived. She was depleted by that seance—never having had a strong constitution and having lost so much blood during the ceremony. But slowly, her health was restored.

Trista: That was a risky night. But accidents are common in arcanum; the slightest of changes can lead to completely different results.

Trista: If my little sister were a little younger, or if she were pushed a little harder ...

Trista: ... She would've seen what I saw. Hundreds of soldiers lying dead on a battlefield, children orphaned before their very eyes, the endless explosions, and those golden rabbits ...

Trista: I was this close to having a little sister who's just like me.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Hundred Spoons

CH17701-02

A Hundred Spoons

Front Lobby

Dittarsdorf: Glad to have you here, old friend.

Dittarsdorf gets to his feet and extends a welcoming hand. This is the beginning of an amicable conversation.

His friend strides up to him and shakes his hand.

Dittarsdorf: Truth be told, I've considered many people for this job—many! But none suits the position better than you.

Dittarsdorf: You're being modest, my friend. I had thought about getting her a governess ...

Dittarsdorf: ... Governesses may well raise ordinary ladies, but my little girl is anything but. I'll settle for nothing but the very best for her.

???: "She must be virtuous, pure of thought, elegant, and compliant."

???: "She must be clever but guileless, talented yet modest, and dignified without pretension. Then, she will be a true noble lady."

???: ... Heh heh.

???: Parents always have grand expectations for their children, don't they?

The child places a finger horizontally below her nose, mimicking a mustache as she speaks.

???: I'm a decent gentleman with impeccable manners. I never attend an event to which I am not invited.

???: I have a warm smile, a kind heart, and I never push others away. I have strong morals, respect social etiquette, and always present the best side of myself to others—when it's necessary.

???: Dittarsdorf regards me as a "true noble gentleman." He believes I possess every quality an honorable man should have.

The man maintains an upright posture, clasping his hands behind his back, his shoulders perfectly squared.

???: That's why, despite my eagerness to attend and the fact that I'm a family friend, I've never asked for, nor even hinted at wanting, an invitation to that banquet.

???: I know that asking is pointless. I must be patient.

???: When the time comes, the gate will be open to me.

???: The Dittarsdorf house is guarded by an enormous gate. It's beautiful and stately, made of metal, and artistically decorated with the family's motifs.

???: It's quite a feat, really—finding the balance between beauty and security.

???: And my friend Dittarsdorf has found that balance. His only lacking feature, of which he is fully aware, is the patience to educate a child.

???: He worries, you see—about a future in which his son is incompetent and chaotic and his daughter is crude and reckless. So, he's pinned his hopes on me.

???: ...

The countenance of a middle-aged man faintly emerges on the girl's face. She licks her teeth—an unconscious display of greed.

Two figures in dresses emerge from the darkness and approach the gate. With a heavy rumble, it slides open.

???: Oh my. We've been talking all this time, yet we haven't so much as mentioned Isolde ...

She reaches out a hand and seizes your wrist. A gentle yet irresistible force leads you forward.

???: She should've been at the center of this conversation. So sweet and gentle—a truly thoughtful and beautiful girl.

She doesn't look back.

???: I treated her as my own. I taught her everything I knew, and she became that perfect young lady Dittarsdorf desired.

???: She was flawless. She met every expectation—from her mother, her father, her brother, the servants, and, of course, me.

Middle-Aged Male: Mind your posture, child.

Isolde: Yes, Mr. Karl.

Little Isolde's body tenses. She straightens her back further.

Karl: Very well. Now lift your chin a little. No, not too high. We must avoid any indication of overconfidence.

Isolde: ...

Karl: ... That's right. Just like that. Very well done, my child.

He lays his hands on the back of the chair in front of him and nods to his student on the other side of the hallway.

Karl: Alright, now maintain that posture and walk to me.

Isolde: Yes, Mr. Karl.

It is rather premature for a girl of only twelve to learn to walk in 3-inch heels. But practicing now will avoid any future embarrassment.

Isolde: Head up, shoulders square. Alright, now smooth strides. Don't sway, and don't bounce up and down.

Breathe in. Step forward, waist balanced. And again.

Isolde: Don't lean forward. Straighten your back. Knees steady.

No mistakes. Don't make any mistakes.

Isolde: *exhales in relief*

She stops before the chair, awaiting her teacher's feedback.

Six years have passed. She's shot up since her first seance.

Her days of reaching up for door handles are long gone. She stands there, a living example of perfection—all thanks to her education.

Karl: Excellent, Isolde. Your walk is almost perfect now.

The gentleman smiles and pulls out the chair.

Karl: Have a seat. Let's move on to our next subject.

Karl: Time is against us, young lady. We spent an extra fifteen minutes working on your posture.

Karl: I've been told that you'll have a vocal lesson later. Don't worry, I shall see you again for our literature class after its completion.

Karl: Tonight we'll be reading about a dinner. There will be mention of the dining etiquette we've practiced before, so this is a good chance for you to review it.

Isolde: ... Certainly, Mr. Karl.

The girl gracefully sits down. A maid hurries over and helps her adjust the chair. A bowl of vegetable soup is sitting before her.

Isolde: May I ask a question, sir?

Isolde: ... If I remember correctly, you told me that we had completed the rules of dining etiquette last week. Did I misunderstand?

Karl: You did not, my child.

The gentleman picks up a silver spoon and places it in her open palm. One by one, he adjusts her fingers until they close around the spoon handle.

Karl: But last night, during dinner with your parents, I couldn't help but notice that your hands were shaking.

Karl: The movements were subtle—almost imperceptible most of the time. You even hid them well while you cut the meat.

Karl: When it came to the soup, however, the shaking was as clear as daylight. People will certainly notice your wetted cuffs.

With a smile on his face, Karl loosens his grip. Little Isolde needs no further instruction.

Her countenance is composed, yet her hand is trembling. Her fingertips turn pale as she tightens her grip on the spoon.

Karl: Of course, such a mistake wouldn't be considered rude, but it would reflect badly on your education.

Karl: We've put in great effort and come so far. It would be a great shame to fall short on so small a detail.

Isolde: Yes, Mr. Karl ... I'll work hard on it.

Karl: A hundred times.

The gentleman paces around the lounge, feeling utterly complacent about his work.

Karl: I asked her to practice it a hundred times.

Karl: She's the daughter of Evangeline, the greatest opera singer to ever grace the stages of Vienna. She has her eyes, her nose, her cheeks ... How could she possibly have such a shaky hand while using a spoon?

Karl: What a disgrace.

He shakes his head, his dark hair on the back of his head shining with vitality.

Karl: I could tell she was getting tired towards the end of the session. She'd hidden it well thus far, just as she'd been instructed to do.

Karl: She's only twelve, after all, and she went straight from a three-hour poise and posture class to repeatedly raising and lowering the spoon for an hour more.

Karl: But she carried on. Just as I expected her to.

Karl: She had a smile on her face. Her voice remained soft. Her eyes were gentle as a spring breeze. She's a darling little lamb.

Karl: All our efforts paid off ...

He stops by the window. His gaze fixed upon the garden lawn.

Evangeline sits in the sunshine, a white rabbit in her arms. She's stroking it, gently grooming its hair.

Karl: Her wrists were still tight and shaky the first twenty times we practiced. It wasn't until the 65th attempt that things started to improve.

Karl: Perhaps she was too tired to shake; perhaps her joints were numb. Or perhaps she finally mastered the skill and calmed herself.

Karl: By the 100th practice, the soup in her spoon was as still as a mirror. I could see the reflection of my face within it.

Karl's eyes flicker back to the table.

The soup is now cold and thick. The chair is pulled out, and Isolde is nowhere to be found.

Karl: I still have no idea why she was trembling so much. Maybe there's an issue with the muscles in her hand, or maybe it's an unfortunate side effect of her inherited ability.

Karl: But I'm certain that she'll be rid of this unsightly habit within a week.

Karl: She will become Evangeline, only better.

Karl: This, you see, is the benefit of a proper education. If only I could travel back in time and give poor Evangeline the same opportunities ...

Karl: ...

Karl: You seem surprised. Why?

Karl: I adore Evangeline. I'll forever be her loyal audience member and supportive friend. But that doesn't mean that I'm blind to her flaws.

Karl: She's mad. Unstable. She spends half the day unconscious and the other half, God bless, in hysteria—even incontinence. She's a pitiful woman, indeed, worthy of little admiration.

Karl: Yes, she's the center of the crowd; yes, important figures attend her seances and listen to her piously; and yes, throngs of people cheer and throw flowers at her on stage, some even fainting from the excitement.

Karl: But none of this speaks to who she truly is, my dear friend.

He shrugs.

The cold soup morphs into a slice of chocolate cake as he sits down at the table.

Karl: You must be familiar with Sachertorte: two pieces of chocolate cake with a layer of apricot jam in the middle. It's the sweet embodiment of perfection.

With a silver fork in one hand, he flips the piece of cake on its side, revealing a moldy corner.

Karl: Evangeline is just like this cake. Most of her is sweet—her voice, her divination—but there's a rot growing that will one day devour her.

Karl: It's still a little early to throw the cake away. That would be a shame—at least most of it still looks fine.

He cuts through the cake with his fork, precisely avoiding the molding edge.

Karl: We can still enjoy the good part of the cake, as long as we're careful about where the dessert fork lands—Dittarsdorf did marry her, after all.

Karl: But it's a somewhat troublesome process.

Karl: The people's appetite for Sachertortes will never wane. And as one cake sours, they will look for another. Poor Evangeline simply cannot satisfy their desires any longer. They need something fresh, delicious, sweet ...

He savors the cake, a smile growing on his face.

Karl: Isolde is that new confectionary. Freshly out of the oven and waiting to be served.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Blissful Decadence

CH17701-03

Blissful Decadence

Bedroom

Isolde: ... Ha.

Isolde quietly closes the door and sits on the side of her bed. She falls back and stares at the ceiling.

Her body aches, her hands and feet feel like lead, and her eyes are swollen from fatigue. Her headache worsens at night, so she rarely sleeps well.

Isolde: The cotton pads didn't help. The heels still rubbed my feet ...

Isolde: The vocal lesson's over, and my literature class is canceled because Mr. Karl was invited to a banquet ...

Isolde: ... Looks like I can rest early today. Wonderful.

She turns her head to the side, and her eyes meet another's. A young girl lies beside her, with features that resemble her own.

Their foreheads press against each other. The girl's eyes are hollow, only filled with golden tears. Her lips open and close as she mutters a question—one that has been asked many times before.

???: ——, ————————, ——?

Isolde: No, sister, I won't ...

???: ——? —!

Isolde trembles from the cold, just as she did as a frightened baby in her cradle.

???: ——, ————————? ——!!

The girl giggles, curling her arms around Isolde's neck and clutching at her like a vine wrapped around a tree.

Her little body swells, becoming cold and heavy like a piece of iron.

Isolde: Urrh ...

Here she goes again with her usual games. Whenever Isolde is tired and weary, Trista seeks her out to "play" like this.

Isolde: Please, sister, you're hurting me ...

Isolde's breathing becomes short and violent. She can feel her insides being squeezed.

Tears flood her eyes, her face swollen and wet as she silently weeps. Only in moments like this does she let out her true emotions.

Isolde: Urh ... *vomits*

The pressure makes her nauseous.

Trista giggles, her laughter lingering in the room.

More and more spirits start to gather. They whisper to each other, laughing and teasing Isolde, curiously awaiting her next move.

Isolde manages to grab the back of one of her sister's hands with her trembling fingers.

Isolde: Sis ... Ma ... *coughs* Mama ...

Isolde: Mama ... asked for me ... I promised her ...

The girl straddling her waist gives a slow blink. She lets go of Isolde's hands and dissipates into thin air.

This always works. They are both, or at least once were, their mother's closest supporters.

Isolde: Um ... Ha ...

Isolde climbs out of bed, wiping the tears and specks of vomit from her cheeks with a corner of her bed sheet. She mumbles.

Isolde: Mama ...

Lobby

Isolde: Mama.

Her mother looks up from the two rabbits cradled in her arms—one white, the other yellow—and her pale face radiates a smile.

Evangeline: Isolde, my sweet girl, come!

Evangeline: See, I have Apfelstrudel and Blume here. Oh, and the nightingale your father just bought ... I was hoping to take the swan in here too, but it was swimming on the lake, so we couldn't get close to it.

This mother is sometimes more of a child than her own daughter.

She is cheerful and innocent. Simple as a blank canvas. She is always a pleasure to spend time with.

Isolde closes her eyes, erasing her sister's decayed face and the vomit-stained sheet from her mind.

Isolde: We can meet in the garden, Mama. You don't have to bring them all inside ...

Evangeline: Nonsense. I'm happy to do this for you.

Evangeline: You always get dizzy under the sun. How can you attend your lessons if you're unwell?

Evangeline: The lounge is much better. We can enjoy a bit of sunshine through the windows and listen to music.

Her mother pats the cushion next to her. Isolde sits on it, taking Apfelstrudel, the pale yellow rabbit, into her arms.

Isolde: Hello, little Apfelstrudel ... How're you feeling?

Isolde: You're so fluffy and soft! Like the cooked apple in a real strudel ...

She holds the rabbit, stroking its fur and looking into its eyes.

Evangeline: She has the softest fur—and such adorable coloring.

Evangeline: Do you remember when your father first brought them home?
You were eleven—a bit shorter than you are now. It wasn't long after you started your vocal lessons.

Isolde: Of course, Mama. Apfelstrudel and Blume are the only rabbits who've joined the family.

Isolde: We've had plenty of birds and ponies before, as well as white rabbits for use in the seances, but none of them ever had a name.

Isolde: It wasn't until the doctor recommended a new method of therapy that Father brought these two home, and we named them.

Evangeline: *chuckles* Yes. It was fun.

Evangeline: With these adorable little things around, I don't faint as often as I used to. You were so small back then. I can scarcely believe that that little girl is the same person as the fifteen-year-old young lady sitting before me. And for her to be so beautiful a singer, too!

The sun shines through the window, enveloping Evangeline. With a peaceful smile on her face, she continues to stroke the rabbit in her arms.

Isolde: Mama ...

Isolde: Do you not wish to go back on stage? Singing used to be so important to you ...

Evangeline: ... No.

She maintains the smile on her face.

Evangeline: You're mistaken, my child. I never really loved performing. It was just an ordinary part of my life.

Evangeline: Besides, they were making me emotional, which worsened my condition. I shouldn't be performing anymore. It's no good for me.

Isolde: But ...

Evangeline: I'll be fine. As the doctor said, caring for animals brings me peace.

Evangeline: Keeping a calm atmosphere is the foremost goal of this treatment ... Isolde, my child, we must carry on.

Beneath her mother's hopeful gaze, Isolde lowers her head and meekly snuggles up to her.

Isolde: Yes, Mama.
We must carry on.

Evangeline: Things will be different for you, Isolde. You're luckier than I. You've received treatment much earlier in life, and times are better now. There's more than one way to improve your situation ...

Evangeline: You'll be cured. And you have the talent to sing.

Her mother's voice seems to come from above her head. For no clear reason, Isolde feels as though she is speaking from somewhere even higher.

Evangeline: You will become the star of Vienna. You must keep on.

Isolde: Yes, Mama. I'll continue with the treatment. I'll keep on singing.

Isolde: I'll—Hm?

Apfelstrudel has started to nibble on her young master's gloves.

Isolde: Apfelstrudel? Are you hungry?

Evangeline: How could she be? The maids have already fed them today.

Isolde: No, you're confused again, Mama. In March, the doctor suggested that you start feeding them.

Isolde: He said it would help you bond with them.

Evangeline: Is that so ...? Oh yes, I remember ...

Isolde puts down the rabbit and cups her mother's face. She gently pushes her hair aside and softly presses her forehead against her mother's.

Isolde: Don't worry, Mama. We all forget things sometimes. Leave it to me.

Isolde: I'll get them something to eat.

She gets to her feet and makes her way to the other room. But before she leaves, she stops by the door and looks back.

Isolde: Mama, have the rabbits recovered? I noticed they were a little out of spirits earlier.

Isolde: If they're still unwell, I'll go get some medicine, too.

Evangeline: Mm? Were they really?

Evangeline raises the rabbits in her hands so that their faces are level with hers. Their noses are wet, and their eyes are clear. They look as healthy as any rabbit she has seen. A few nameless white rabbits are chasing each other around her feet, each looking as energetic as ever.

Evangeline: They seem ... fine to me.

Isolde: Alright Mama. I'll be back shortly.

Front Lobby

Out of the lounge and through the hall, past the many doorways, down the stairs, and finally to a small room with two maids working inside. The Dittarsdorf house is well-known for its staggering size.

Maid I: Sheets, sheets, and more sheets—I ain't gone a single day without washing these bloody things!

Maid I: When I worked for the Mayers, we only had one or two washing days a week!

Maid II: But you're paid better here, ain't ya? Quit your complainin' and come help, eh?

Maid II: My God, there's blood on the sheets again. How on Earth is there so much of it? Even for that time of the month, this is a lot ...

Maid I: There's no way this is blood from her time of the month.

The red-haired maid crinkles up her nose in disgust.

Maid I: There's been blood on the sheets once a week for the last three weeks now.

Maid I: I'd say it comes from those dead rabbits and birds.

Maid I: Lucas threw away another load of dead animals yesterday. I saw birds, ponies, but mostly rabbits—the yellow and white ones.

Maid I: I've lost count of the number of Apfelstrudels and Blumes we've had. They got two new ones just today ...

Maid II: Poor things. What happened to 'em? They didn't die nearly so often last year. Is there somethin' wrong with the fodder?

Maid I: No, it weren't because of the bloody fodder! It weren't any natural cause of death!

As the maid soaks the sheet in the water, she lowers her voice.

Maid I: Lucas told me that every one of the animals suffered a miserable death. Some vomited blood; others had their heads cracked open. Most strange of all is that a few of 'em had a hole in their neck with a golden key jammed inside.

Maid I: ... He said Lady Evangeline did it.

Maid II: Oh, come off it! Lady Evangeline loves those animals. She's always carryin' those rabbits around in her arms.

Maid I: Well you didn't see her crush that poor nightingale with her bare hands when she was having an episode!

Maid I: She's ill. So is Lady Isolde. It runs in the family, like a curse.

Maid I: The doctor said it was hysteria. Somethin' to do with their "wanderin' wombs." Drives 'em mad and makes 'em bleed and all.

Maid I: Which explains these blood stains.

Maid II: Do you think Lady Isolde will one day lose her mind like her mother?

Maid I: Why do you care?

Maid II: She's been awfully kind to me. She helped me settle in ...

The maid with short, dark hair looks down at the dirty bed sheet in her hands. It is covered in vomit and sweat.

Maid II: She's still young, but she's already such a perfect little lady. Gentle, polite, beautiful, kind ...

Maid II: She's got so many lessons to attend, bless her. Etiquette, literature, history, paintin', music, dance ... And on top of all that, she has to go to the seances with her mother twice a month ...

Maid II: Poor girl ...

She slowly folds up the bed sheet, as if to save Isolde the embarrassment.

Maid II: She don't faint often, and she ain't havin' any manic episodes like her mother does now. But she does vomit and feel dizzy at times ... Oh I do hope she don't end up like her mother ...

Maid I: Yes, yes, enough of the worryin'. It's none of our concern. You done with the sheets? Come on then.

With the laundry baskets stowed under their arms, the maids walk out into the corridor.

Isolde: ...

Isolde: ... Yes, now I remember. I left it in this drawer. Ah, there it is.

She fumbles in the dark until her fingers come across a familiar shape.

She looks at her palm, then into the dimly lit corridor. The maids are long gone by now, but their conversation still lingers in her ears.

Isolde: Father once told me ...

She shuts her eyes in calm determination.

Isolde: Be graceful, be self-restrained, and be kind to others.

Isolde: Be compassionate, especially towards the less privileged.

Isolde: We ... must be an example for our people, we—

Theophil: We must be virtuous and dignified, as befits our status.

Isolde: ... Theophil! I didn't know you were home today.

She opens her eyes. Her brother, two years her senior, is standing next to her.

Theophil: I won't be staying long. Mother told me you were here, so I came.

Theophil: It's been a while! I brought you this.

He pulls a little velvet box and a pocket watch from his jacket pocket.

Theophil: The box is from Heinrich. There's a brooch inside—for your fifteenth birthday.

Isolde: And this watch?

Theophil: That's from me.

Isolde: But you already gave me a present on my birthday, Theophil.

Theophil: No, it's not for your birthday. I just want you to have it. Look, it's not just a watch. It has a timer, and here ...

He presses the little knob on the pocket watch, and, with a quiet click, it flips open.

Theophil: See? It's white crystal. It works like an amulet to help you stay calm. And here, see the slot? It can hold enough smelling salts for twenty uses.

Theophil: You need a watch to keep track of the time in all those lessons, and the amulet and smelling salts will help you, too. It's perfect.

He presses the watch into his sister's hand. There is a beat of silence. He speaks again.

Theophil: I also have news for you: I'm renting a studio. It's amazing how much it's helped me gain inspiration!

Theophil: It also has space for the young models to stay the night when the weather becomes dreadful. It simply broke my heart to see them walking all the way back home in the rain.

Theophil: So, all is well with me, but I won't be returning home very frequently. I hope you'll continue your treatment along with Mother. Remember, I'm thinking of you all the time. You are my beloved little sister, after all.

Isolde: ... Did Father agree to this?

Theophil: Of course! You can ask him if you like. He even helped pick the studio.

He turns around and waves to their father, a bright, beautiful smile on his face. For a moment, he looks like the herald of spring.

Isolde: I see. Then I'm relieved. I wish only the best for you, Theophil.

The spring's favored son leaves as briskly as the wind. He crosses the lounge, passes through the doors, and goes out into the boundless world.

Dittarsdorf stands next to his daughter, a hand on her shoulder. He shakes his head.

Dittarsdorf: I have a blundering artist for a son. A wild spirit. Look at him. Who would think that he's almost seventeen?

Dittarsdorf: You're nothing like him, for which I'm very grateful. You spend your days perfecting yourself, while he wastes time chasing after those models in his—

Dittarsdorf: *sighs* What I'm trying to say is that you're a comfort to me, child.

Isolde: Thank you, Father. How generous of you to say such nice things about me.

She smiles with an adorable shyness and looks down at the floor, as most young daughters would after making their father proud.

But her eyes flicker towards the door. With Theophil gone, it is shut again. Only a thin beam of light shines through the gap.

Isolde: Theophil didn't inherit Mother's musical talents. He doesn't even sing.

Isolde: Mother passed that talent down to me instead of her firstborn son. I suppose it's unfair to him.

Under her father's silent gaze, Isolde turns and makes her way to the other end of the house.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Mirror of Tears

CH17701-04

Mirror of Tears

???: Hello, excuse me ... What is this place?

A timid face appears in the dark. Bewildered and uneasy, its owner wipes her hands on her dress, where there once was an apron.

???: Me? My name is Hannah. I'm a waitress at Café Central. Have we met?

Hannah: Oh ... I see. Sorry ...

Hannah: I was just at the café, working my shift. The manager told me to walk slower so that I wouldn't kick the customers' chair legs again, and then everything went dark, and I found myself in this very room!

Hannah: This is strange! Stranger than a novel!

Hannah: I was hoping you could tell me what happened—explain things to me.

She paces around, looking anxious.

Hannah: ... Mm? What's this?

One of her shoes hits something firm. She crouches down curiously.

Hannah: Oh! It's ... a painting? No ... a door?

Hannah: How strange that it's on the floor. Actually, it looks like the door to Café Central ...

Hannah: Something's written on it. It's too dark in here. I can't see. Maybe I can feel it with my fingers ... Mm?

She stops and furrows her eyebrows. She runs her fingers across the doorplate a few more times.

The name carved on it kisses the tips of her fingers. A sweet bitterness fills her heart.

Hannah: ... Theophil? Mr. Theophil ...?

Hannah: Did he play a part in the kidnapping? But why would an artist be involved in such a horrible act ...?

She mumbles to herself, her eyes rolling in the dark. She is looking for an excuse. An excuse to forgive.

Hannah: Or perhaps—perhaps he wants me to be his model? I'd gladly agree to it, of course ...

Hannah: He's so handsome and kind, and my goodness, can he paint! Any girl would agree to be his model. He wouldn't need to abduct me for that ...

A fragment of a memory comes back to her, but it's vague. Shrouded in a white haze.

Hannah: Oh, I think I remember!

Hannah: Before everything went dark, Mr. Theophil had ordered another Franziskaner. I had it on my tray, and then ...

Hannah: ... And then I passed out before I reached his table ...

Hannah: Until then, it was a perfectly ordinary day ...

The warm color of love fades from her face.

Hannah: Mr. Theophil looked as handsome as ever. He ordered his usual. Even Mr. Heinrich was wearing the same brown blazer ...

Hannah: No, no, that's not right.

Hannah: Something was different that day. Yes. That was the day she first met her. That was the beginning of everything.

She looks at you, trancelike. The door opens beneath her palm.

Café Central

Theophil: An insightful idea, miss.

Theophil: I've never heard of such a perspective on how to treat mental illness ... I'm very impressed.

The cream has long since melted into the Franziskaner. This conversation is much more interesting than the beverages on the table.

Heinrich: See? I told you, Theophil!

Heinrich: I knew you two would get along. How could you not adore such a lovable and talkative lady?

Heinrich: The amazing Klara! We met at an auction. She has a superb taste in the arts!

Heinrich's bouts of excessive enthusiasm are a loveable weakness of his. Rather than annoy, it endears his friends to him.

He sweeps up his friend's cup and takes a huge gulp.

Heinrich: Oh, by the way, Theophil. Where's your sister?

Heinrich: You said she'd be here today. I thought she'd agreed to come down to the café.

Theophil: Yes. She should've arrived by now. Perhaps she's been delayed on her way over.

Theophil: After the huge success of her debut, my little sister is the new star of Vienna. She's positively swarmed by her admirers on the streets—it's all very sweet but, as you can imagine, it can be quite troublesome.

Hannah: Sir, here's your coffee.

The waitress lightly places it on the table.

Hannah: One Vienna iced coffee and a Maria Theresa. Enjoy.

Her gaze lingers on Theophil, an eager smile upon her face. Her light brown hair is carefully tied in a curly ponytail.

Theophil: Thank you, Hannah. Your smile always brightens up a long afternoon.

Hannah: Haha ... You flatter me again, sir.

She blushes and hurriedly looks aside. This is not the first time her dear Theophil has been so sweet to her.

Hannah: Would you like a cake on the side? It-It's on the house.

Hannah: I remember you said you liked the particular lemon aroma of it ... My mother grew those lemons. She brought me some more when she last visited. Would you—

Theophil: Over here!

Heinrich: Oh, Isolde! My dear girl! When was it that we last met? It feels like eons!

Isolde: It was about ... one and a half months ago?

Heinrich: Ah, how unforgivably long! Do you remember when we were younger? We saw each other every week!

Hannah: Theo ...

Her voice is lost among the chatter.
She quietly looks at her sweet Theophil as he gets on his feet and walks up to his sister.

He has completely forgotten about the lemons. Or, rather, he never cared about them in the first place.

Theophil: Why, do you think Isolde is still that little girl who followed you around?

Theophil: I'm afraid you're terribly mistaken, my friend! She's the biggest star of Vienna and the best and most stunning "Salome" of all time! Her admirers fill the streets, and her work has shaken the art world to its very core!

Putting both his hands on her shoulders, he basks in his pride for his sister.

Theophil: And all at the ripe old age of sixteen, no less! She's not some unknown actress taking minor role after minor role, nor is she one of those poets who end their miserable lives by plunging themselves into a river! No, it won't be long before she becomes the sovereign of theater!

Theophil: My point is, Mr. Heinrich, that it's very difficult to see her these days. But, if you can make her brother's life a little sweeter ...

Heinrich: Oh, Theophil, you crafty fellow!

Heinrich gently punches his arm. Theophil giggles as he pulls himself away from his fist.

The café is filled with their youthful laughter.

Isolde: ...

Theophil is not yet twenty. He looks young, sweet, and happy. As free as the wind.

Hannah moves her lips, nervously rubbing her hands on her apron as she tries to come up with more words to get his attention.

She notices that Isolde is looking at her and lightly shaking her head.

Isolde: Thank you, but I don't feel like having a drink.

Hannah: It was her! Her! How could I forget? How could I forget her!?

Hannah: Oh, what a terrible, terrible future ...

Hannah: Did I hit my head? Or was it my neck? Or my legs? My waist? ... No, no, no, no ...

Small beads of sweat glisten on the tip of her nose. She checks on her neck, her back, and her limbs, making sure they are still attached to her body.

Eventually, her hands stop at her neck.

Hannah: It was here. Yes.

Clutching her neck with both hands, she crouches down on the floor.

Hannah: So much pain ... There was ... *sobs*

Hannah: Why? Why did it have to be me? Why not Teresa? Or Gregor?

Hannah: Not all who were trampled that day died. Nor those who fell to the floor ... And those who were pushed in front of the guns ... They had a quick and painless death, at least.

Hannah: Why me ...? Why only me ...?

Hannah: Why was I the only one who fell down the stairs? Why was I the only one who screamed in agony? Why was I the only one who suffered a broken neck?

Hannah: It shouldn't have happened—none of this should've happened! The road shouldn't have been covered in sharp gravel!

Hannah: Those creatures in black, with their dark slime dripping all over ... They started that demonstration!

Hannah: It was ... those creatures ...

Hannah: Monsters ...

Hannah drops her head. Tears stream down her cheeks, dripping on her palms, and pooling on the door beneath her feet.

The door is now tightly shut. The door to the café with Theophil's name on it.

On the other side, Cupid and Psyche convene.

Hannah: It was "The Circle." It was the speech.

Hannah: It was they who were responsible.

The puddle of tears beneath her feet confronts her with her own reflection. Her reflected face morphs into someone else's. Isolde.

Hannah: The famous opera singer with a touch of sorrow.

Hannah: The daughter of that mirror peddler.

Hannah: They killed me.

Klara: Hello, I'm Klara Vingler. Perhaps you've heard of "The Vingler's Mirror." That's an invention of my family.

From the other side of the table, the lady in the green dress extends a white-gloved hand.

She is leaning forward so far that she is no longer sitting in her chair. This may appear to be too eager, but the smile on her face is sincere.

Klara: Heinrich told me a lot about you and your brother. I'm most glad that we've finally had the chance to meet.

Isolde: I'm Isolde.

Isolde takes her hand.

Isolde: It's a privilege to make your acquaintance.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Gray Eyes

CH17701-05

Gray Eyes

???: Yes, yes. She is Salome.

???: She's mine ...

???: My Salome. My muse.

Admirer I: Brava!

Applause.

Admirer II: Brava! Fantastic—truly fantastic!

Another Applause. Cliche. Boring.

They are merely spectators, distant observers. Their understanding of her is shallow. Of course it is.

The concept of a "seance performance" has captivated the minds of the people. The hall is filled to the rafters with a crowd eager to see the horrific dead descend on this beautiful singer with their own eyes.

Admirer III: Humph. This can't possibly be a real performance!

Some lower their voices, whispering in the silences between the cheers and applause.

Admirer III: One cannot deny that she has become the character, but surely this is some sort of fraud!

Admirer III: That voice is not her voice, and that dance is not her dance. Not even her expressions are her own!

Admirer III: She's not performing. She's just using that freakish power of hers! This is witchcraft—insanity, I tell you!

Praise, slander, their so-called "fair" judgments—all are like a raging fire, a freezing gust.

They gaze at her face and the movement of her body, and listen to her sing.

But never do they think about, nor try to understand, who she is after the curtain falls.

They only see her performance, the spirits channeling through her. No one has ever seen her true self.

Isolde: *singing*

No one but me.

Yes, only me.

Isolde: !

I look at her, and I see "her." Not those spirits, but herself.

I understand her.

I am loyal to her, now and forever. She is my love and my muse.

Ring Road

Isolde: Oh, be careful, Ms. Klara ...

The rain has just stopped. Isolde walks out of the café with her friend.

Klara: Don't worry. I'm used to cleaning the stains off my skirts and shoes.

Klara: Although it is good to be careful. I don't want to have to wash them every time it rains. It would consume far too much of my study time.

The girl in green winks at Isolde. Her eyes sparkle behind her round glasses.

She hoists up her skirt, takes a half-step back, and deftly leaps over the puddle in front of her.

Isolde: Ah, you ...

Isolde: You know, I've never thought of simply jumping over the puddles. Isn't it a little too ... eye-catching?

Klara: Well, maybe so.

They link arms as they walk together. The distance between them is close to zero.

They are two new best friends.

Klara: Especially when we're strolling arm in arm like this. A synchronized leap would look rather odd.

Klara: But it makes a lot of sense when you're esca—ahem, running.

Klara: Of course, if you're running down the street, a jump will make you no more eye-catching than you already are. But if you're in a hurry, you'll be leaving the sight of others before you even notice that they're staring at you.

Isolde: Ah, like when you ran out of Ms. Hornberg's window?

Klara: Yes, just like—What!?

She covers her mouth with one hand, her eyes wide with surprise.

Klara: H-how did you know that? I thought no one living on that street knew of me!

Isolde: Hah hah! You should pay better attention to your surroundings.

Isolde chuckles and looks to the other side of the street.

Isolde: Anyway, you're right that you'd quickly leave people behind, but they'd still have their eyes fixed on you until you were out of their sight.

Isolde: And it wouldn't end there. Their curiosity would only continue to grow. Who is she? Where's she going? Before you know it, the seeds of mystery will have blossomed in every corner of Vienna.

She looks back at Kakania and reaches out a hand to tuck a stray hair away from her face.

Isolde: Not to mention that there's no other "witch" who would ever jump out of the window of a noble lady's room but you.

???: ...

???: That was a lovely day. The sun shone brightly once the rain stopped.

???: And that was the day she first recognized my existence.

The woman in gray closes the notebook in her hand and steps out of the shadows.

Playwright: I'm a playwright. Please address me as such.

Playwright: Please, you must call me by this title. I implore you ...

The playwright stands in front of you. Now that she is closer, you can feel a nip in the air.

A layer of gray fog envelops her, coloring the hem of her skirt gray, too. Water is dripping from her clothes, forming a puddle on the ground.

Playwright: Oh yes, my clothes are soaked—I'm soaked. It's a long story.

Playwright: And an unimportant one. Or, rather, the least important. No, we must start with the most essential part of the tale. Here, hold my hands ...

She reaches out her hands to you. They are icy cold to the touch.

Playwright: Allow me to introduce you to my father first. No, this isn't the beginning of the story, just an appropriate character to introduce it with.

Playwright: Schmiler, Topaz Schmiler, was a man with black hair and gray eyes.

Playwright: His father was a cloth merchant, and his grandfather owned a small farm.

Playwright: Having grown up in a financially sound environment, he didn't have to worry about feeding and clothing himself. This gave him the chance to come into contact with "art" and "beauty."

Playwright: Thus, he became a gentleman. He was polite, read poetry, visited exhibitions, appreciated paintings ...

Playwright: ... and watched opera. This was his favorite. He was deeply moved by the art form and attended the theater regularly.

Playwright: Later, he married my mother, a lesser-known opera singer. She wasn't famous and generally played supporting roles.

Playwright: A year after that, I was born.

Playwright: Family? No, no. I wouldn't call us a family. Or, more specifically, I wouldn't count my father as a family member ...

Playwright: He rarely spent time with us, nor did he have any kind of real job. He was far too busy writing poems and melodies. Despite that, he never managed to complete a piece. Just as he never managed to return home.

Playwright: It was my grandfather who took care of me and my mother. I suffered no hardships. I lived a similar childhood to my father.

Playwright: I received an education, was exposed to art, and was loved by my mother and grandfather just as he was.

Playwright: I lived a life of calm, stability, and happiness. And, as a result, I came to understand him less and less.

Playwright: Why would he choose to leave such a warm and loving family to live in a riverside cabin all by himself?

Playwright: What did Grandfather mean by "meaningless obsession" when they were quarreling?

She gives a slight frown as she looks up at the ceiling.

Playwright: The distance between us fed the confusion and disdain in my heart. At the age of fifteen, I realized that his face had become faint to me.

Playwright: It was ... blurred, like a wrinkled handwritten letter with tear-smudged ink.

Playwright: Her gray eyes look cold and hard, like pebbles at the bottom of a river.

Playwright: I was terrified. I knew we weren't close, but I didn't want to be a bad daughter who couldn't even remember her father's face. So I tried and tried. I tried my best to recall him.

After a quick blink, she narrows her eyes.

Playwright: But, as it turned out, my efforts were unnecessary.

Playwright: Three days after I started trying in earnest, my father ran out of his cabin, screaming and crying, and jumped into the river. It was mid-winter. He was fished out—dead.

Playwright: Mother fainted when she heard the news. Grandfather fell ill and was bedridden. So, I took a carriage to the river by myself.

Playwright: That was the first time I saw my father completely clearly. I realized there was no need for me to worry about being a bad daughter.

Playwright: After confirming the identity of the body, I went to his cabin with the patrol.

Playwright: They helped me stack his things in the carriage and handed me a notebook. "This proves that your father committed suicide," they said.

Playwright: ...

Playwright: I read it, of course.

She clenches the notebook in her hand. Her previously wandering gaze fixes on you.

Playwright: Then, I finally knew where he went when he wasn't home.

Playwright: He went to the Vienna State Opera, to Weigl's Dreher Park, to Der Graben.

Playwright: But he wasn't there for shopping or sightseeing. He was there for her. For Evangeline!

Playwright: She was the only thing on his mind. He praised her. He missed her. He began stalking her.

Playwright: He followed her from the moment she left her house until the moment she returned home. He even bribed her doctor to give him first-hand information on her health!

Playwright: The burning passion in these scrawls surpassed all the poems and melodies he'd ever written, you know?

Playwright: Simply reading those words scalded me. They were hot, stifling, so much so that they almost killed me.

Playwright: I was trembling in fear.

Playwright: But I didn't know what I was scared of. So, I kept reading in the freezing wind by the river, one page after another, until I'd read every word.

She talks faster and faster, a frantic enthusiasm taking over her body. She almost swallows her tongue in her eagerness to recount the tale.

Playwright: The last—last page—the last page was moist! Can you imagine!? It was smudged by tears, just as my father's face was in my memory!

Playwright: Who is this person with "curly black hair, a pale face, and a body as delicate as a champagne flute?"

Playwright: What kind of person is a woman with a "perfect and indisputable charisma"?

Playwright: I was desperate to find out. Before I could realize what I was doing, I'd started running. I ran and ran until I arrived at the doors of the opera house.

Playwright: I had run so fast that there was sweat on my brow, even on that cold winter day. I asked about Evangeline's performance, only to find that she had retired in order to recuperate from her illness ...

Playwright: ...

The playwright calms herself. Her breathing softens as if she hadn't said a word.

Playwright: ... Several years later, in mid-June, I heard that Evangeline drowned in the beautiful pond in her garden.

She gives you a gentle smile.

Playwright: You see, it was time she followed in my father's footsteps.

Playwright: I never met her—I never had a chance to meet her, let alone hear the singing that had driven my father mad. Oh, don't get me wrong. I don't say this out of regret.

She grips your hands even tighter. It is impossible to pull away.

Playwright: Because Isolde, her daughter, had her debut half a month after her mother's death.

Playwright: I was there, just as my father had been at every one of Evangeline's performances. I witnessed her rendition of The Dance of the Seven Veils and how she enraptured the whole of Vienna.

Playwright: In my father's notes, I had glimpsed the first sign of her existence in the swollen ovaries of a rabbit.

Playwright: I know when she took her first step, how painful her night seizures were, even the amount of calming syrup she took.

Playwright: I'm my father's daughter, and she Evangeline's.

Playwright: How beautiful fate is. How it binds us together.

Meeting Room, Theater

Troupe Leader: ... You mean, this is your original script?

The leader of the opera troupe looks up from the thick manuscript on the table, a stiff expression on his face.

Playwright: Y-yes, sir, this is an original, created b-by me ...

Troupe Leader: Hmm ...

Troupe Leader: Ms. Schmiler, I very much appreciate your hard work and persistence. Your grandfather contacted me and told me how passionate you are about playwriting.

Troupe Leader: There's no doubt that you've put in great effort. I can see that you're wholly devoted to your craft, which is certainly a necessary quality for a playwright ...

Troupe Leader: ... And you're the granddaughter of my good friend. I even attended your debutante ball. So, a much as it pains me to disappoint you ...

He closes his eyes. When he opens them again, there is an apologetic look on his face.

Troupe Leader: ... We cannot accept your script, my child.

Playwright: Why?

Troupe Leader: It's much too risky. The story, that is.

Troupe Leader: I understand that many stories are inspired by true events, but yours is simply far too obvious.

Troupe Leader: Rosalie, the pretty and gentle heroine from a noble family, becomes popular after playing Salome ...

Troupe Leader: Her mother murders her father; her brother burns himself to death; yet she herself is sociable and surrounded by many friends ...

Troupe Leader: Together, they create an organization called the "Square," based in Café Central. Every day they talk about poems, share their thoughts and ideas ...

His voice gets lower and lower. Beads of sweat start to form on his forehead.

Troupe Leader: Later, after Rosalie's father dies, her tutor shows his desire for her ...

Troupe Leader: He claims to be her godfather. He longs for Rosalie so strongly that he threatens her with his power. Even worse, he plans to murder her best friend Maggie ...

Playwright: Exactly, sir! This evil man manipulates Rosalie into dancing for him in a veil!

Playwright: How delicate, how kind, how pitiful she is!

Playwright: She's never hurt a soul, she's always kind-hearted, and her gentle nature evokes empathy from everyone. She is sure to stir compassion within the audience's hearts ...

Playwright: And in the most crucial scene, her hero arrives, pulling her out of the darkness!

Playwright: He enters, a beacon of shining light, bringing salvation and happiness to Rosalie and slaying Cameron the devil!

The playwright shoots to her feet, knocking over the chair she was sitting on.

Playwright: Isn't it a wonderful play, sir?

Playwright: Why are you turning it down? Is it because of the buyout fee?

Playwright: I won't charge you much! As long as Isolde stars in it, everything is negotiable!

Troupe Leader: No, no, I mean to say ...

The leader mops his sweaty brow.

Troupe Leader: The characters are too familiar to us.

Troupe Leader: Any audience member with a modicum of knowledge would know they're based on Ms. Isolde, her brother Theophil, their parents, and Mr. Karl ...

Troupe Leader: Although Mr. and Mrs. Dittarsdorf are no longer living, and Mr. Theophil, wherever he might be, isn't the sort to criticize a piece of art, Mr. Karl will not at all be happy about it!

Troupe Leader: He'd never allow us to put it on! It's absolutely slanderous!

Playwright: No, it's not!

Playwright: I saw it all! He was reaching for Isolde's waist—that filthy toad! What are you so afraid of!?

Playwright: It didn't end well. I returned home with my script in hand.

Playwright: That donkey has no appreciation for art. He even accused me of being an untalented writer!

Playwright: How dare he say that I'm "merely repeating the facts" and that it's "just an ersatz copy of Salome" ...

Playwright: I'm a playwright! You address me as such, do you not? How could I possibly hand over a manuscript as terrible as he said?

Playwright: Oh, he even said that "Mr. Karl is a kind gentleman." Ha! Preposterous!

Playwright: I was always by Ms. Isolde's side. No one knew her better than I. I knew her friends, her family, and all about that d**nable old man ...

Playwright: ... and he was just as I described in the script! She, too, was as I described. Young, beautiful, and fragile as a daffodil.

Playwright: Even aging couldn't befall her! That family curse has ensured that nobody in her family has lived past the age of 40!

Playwright: We're all familiar with the events that followed. Theophil set himself on fire, and Isolde became fragile and pain-filled. She eventually received shock therapy in full view of the public ...

Playwright: She was ... trembling. The pain looked excruciating. I'd never seen her like that ...

Playwright: I wanted to scream. I wanted to stand up and yell at Schwartz to stop the torture. I wanted to. But I couldn't move. I couldn't speak. I couldn't do anything ...

She releases your hands.

Playwright: But then, I did it! I stood up!

Playwright: I scolded him. I ordered him to stop using that barbaric treatment.

Playwright: ...

She clasps her hands together.

Playwright: Soon after, I raised a duel against him and won. I killed Schwartz.

Playwright: You see, that's when I realized it was I who was her hero. My script was always correct. We became close friends after that.

Playwright: There's no more Maggie. We lived happily ever after.

Playwright: Ah, I'm sure this might sound a little different from the story you know, but you have to understand ...

Playwright: You and I are different. There are clairvoyants in my family. My father had prophetic dreams, and so did I. Some say that it's a hereditary mental disorder, but that's not true.

Playwright: In my father's notebook, on a drenched page, he wrote, "This world is a false one."

Playwright: Because he had seen the true one, the one where Evangeline is still on stage, performing. He set off to find that world.

The playwright looks down and holds out the notebook to you. It's gray and soaked. Water drips from its surface.

Playwright: I went to that river again, but it was buried.

Playwright: Where the river once was, a railroad was built, bringing countless travelers to the city.

Playwright: I lay on the tracks, and then I heard a rumbling sound.

Playwright: I ... lay ... on them ...

Her hand does not waver. She is still trying to pass you the notebook.

Playwright: She is my ... Salome ...

Playwright: ...

The smell of river water fills the air. You see the playwright's mouth moving, but no sound can be heard.

Hands shaking, she drops the notebook and grasps her neck.

Another voice replaces hers, squeezing out through her throat.

???: Ha.

You recognize the voice.

Trista: What a sickly little story! How on Earth did you make it to the end?

Trista: Honestly, I deserve a peppermint for cutting her off for you. Don't you think you owe me a thank-you?

She hops over to the table and sits on it.

Trista: But those artists—no, those so-called "artists"—are always over-exaggerating to make their stories more dramatic!

Trista: A muse should be kind, good-looking, and fragile. And my little sister, of course, is more beautiful than a rose and more valuable than a diamond.

Trista: She claimed that no one saw the real Isolde, but did she? Did she see the real her?

Trista stretches out a hand and points into the darkness.

Trista: What can you see when you peer through the cracks around the edges of a door?

Trista: The faster you run, the more curious people become, and the harder they pursue you.

Trista: Don't you think this is all too mushy? Heroes and beauties, salvation and light? Is this really the story?

Trista's hand pulls you near.

Trista: Look. I don't want you to miss this truly dramatic scene.

You look back. The gray door is still cloaked in darkness.

In front of it, a gray eye, wet and hard like a pebble at the bottom of a river, is gazing at you.

TO BE CONTINUED...

By the Curtains

CH17701-06

By the Curtains

Front Lobby

Isolde: Mother, I'm home! ... Mother?

Isolde: That's strange. Has she not come home yet? She should've arrived an hour before me ...

The huge mansion is empty. Mr. Dittarsdorf has sent most of the servants to the farm in the countryside to harvest currants and raspberries.

The fruits need to be harvested in time for the ball in July.

Isolde: Maggie! ... Is Maggie not home either?

Isolde: Oh, look at me. I've been far too busy with rehearsals these days. I'm almost as forgetful as my mother.

Isolde: Maggie took leave to visit her ill mother back in her hometown. Of course she isn't home ...

She murmurs, lifts her skirt, and makes her way to the sideboard.

Isolde: Theophil must've taken that pretty girl, Mia, out with him. She's his new model, so she spends little time at home these days.

Isolde: That leaves the dark-haired Anneli and the lively Agnes. Yes, that's right, they're the only ones here.

She opens a drawer, takes out some food, and looks out the window into the garden.

Isolde: Maggie's away. The bunnies must be hungry.

Isolde: Come out, Apfelstrudel ... Yes, here comes your food.

The little bunny licks her fingertip.

Her fur is soft and fine. It is yet to be replaced by the coarser hair of adulthood.

Isolde: You've accompanied me and Mother for so long, and you've stabilized her condition. Yet still, you go hungry. Poor little things ...

Isolde: Don't worry. I'll be here for you.

Isolde: Although, I will be busy with performances, so it may be tricky to find the time ... The last rehearsal went splendidly, you know. The singing, the dancing, the stage settings—everything was perfect.

Isolde: Heinrich, a friend of mine, has devised many clever tricks for the stage design. Everyone's been telling me that my debut will be fantastic—everyone!

Isolde: Mother will be so glad to hear it.

Isolde: But she's not in the living room or the garden. Where could she be? Hm? What's that voice?

She sets down the bunnies, letting them hop freely in the garden.

???: *singing*

Isolde: That's ... Mother's singing voice ...

She reenters the house and follows the voice through the lounge, down the corridor, up the stairs, and to her parent's bedroom door.

This door, which has always been shut, is now open. She feels the wind blowing through it.

Evangeline: Sleep, my darling, safe and sound ...

It has been forever since Evangeline last sang. Vienna has all but forgotten her voice.

She sings a strange and unfamiliar lullaby, one that has been dug up from the depths of her throat.

Her voice is smooth and clear, like a flowing spring or the glimmering brass needle in her hand that has been driven into Mr. Dittarsdorf's temple.

It was designed to look like a dagger, and now it is serving as a real one.

Isolde's mother pulls the needle from her father's skull. Blood sprays Evangeline's face and soaks the bedsheets. It drips down and pools on the floor.

She is still a superb singer, even in this moment.

Isolde: Mother.

Like a child awakening from a dream, Evangeline trembles and turns her head to see her daughter standing in the doorway.

Evangeline: My Trista! Is that you?

Evangeline: Oh, my dear Trista. Mama's missed you so much ...

Her rosy cheeks glimmer with happiness. She looks like a young girl again.

In this moment, Isolde's mother is like her daughter, and she is more like a mother.

Evangeline: Come, come and see! Your father and I, oh, and Anneli and Agnes, are all ready ...

Evangeline: ... Ready to join you! Oh, my dear Trista, how stupid I was! Just like my mother always said. I thought about it over and over again, but I didn't understand—

Evangeline: I didn't understand it until now. You were right—you were right from the beginning!

Evangeline: You ...

Evangeline regains the visage of a mother. Even her red dress looks heavier on her.

She gently moves her husband's head from her lap to the bed and adjusts his body to a comfortable lying position.

She gets off the bed, steps over Agnes and Anneli's bodies, and wraps her arms tightly around Isolde.

Evangeline: You've always been my smartest, most talented child. My cheerful, clever, unique little angel.

Evangeline: The world has always been nothing but a jester revolving around you, and you the giggling queen.

Isolde: ...

The blood on Evangeline's hands has dried into a powder. It drifts into the air as she moves.

The powder surrounds Isolde and clings to her skin. It immediately causes a rash where it lands, making her itch and burn.

She raises her head. Wind rattles through the window and into the room. She sees the wavering tree tops outside and smells the sweet June flowers.

Isolde: So this is what Father was afraid of ...

Isolde: Yes, and he should've been afraid. The smell of blood is so strong here that, were it to escape through the window, it would make any passerby crinkle their nose. And then people would find out what had happened.

Isolde: This scandal will draw everyone's attention ... Yes ... Even knowing that he may one day be a victim of Mother's hysteria, he considered the reputation of the family above his own life.

Isolde murmurs to herself, ignoring the rashes on her skin and her mother's embrace.

She feels blood in her nose and that squeezing pain in her lower abdomen, just like that night when she was six.

Isolde: Close the window! Close the window! Close the window!!!

Trista: Brava! Brava!

Trista claps, her chin high with pride.

Trista: I'm rather good at telling stories, aren't I?
Did you notice the connection between the two? They even ended in the same way!

Trista: A follow-up? Oh dear, don't tell me you've forgotten already!

Trista: Didn't that "playwright" tell you what happened next? Not long after, before my father's burial, my mother drowned herself in that shallow pond in our garden.

Trista: Yes, you're right. She went insane and considered death the only means to break free.

Trista: She'd had enough of this world. It brought her only anguish. To prevent her from hurting herself, Theophil requested the housemaid guard her door every night.

Trista hops off the table and steps forward.

Trista: You know, even in utter hysteria, she was Vienna's greatest performer.

Trista: On the night of her death, she awoke at midnight, confused.

Trista: She couldn't remember a thing. She asked the maid for a cup of hot milk and honey and wondered why her throat hurt so much, why there were wounds on her hands ...

Trista: The maid, Maggie, obliged and rushed to the kitchen to retrieve it for her.

Trista: In that short time, Evangeline ran across the hallway, down the stairs, through the lounge, and into the garden.

Trista: She didn't stop to look at the clematis, nor did she notice the scent of jasmine in the air.

Trista: She simply leapt into the pond, crawled over to the pearl-shell-decorated fountain, and curled up like an infant in the water ...

She reaches out and touches the slightly ajar metal door before her.

This door doesn't belong to Mr. Karl. You can tell because it's bloodstained and there's a shining dagger hanging on it.

Trista: All the women in our family have met the same end, and Evangeline was no exception.

Trista: The golden rabbits have shown me far too many stories of how my ancestors' lives tragically ended. I have no interest in retelling them.

She pushes the door shut.

Trista: The next morning, when Evangeline's body was discovered in the pond, my little sister fell to the ground, twitching and howling like a drowned cat.

Trista: On that day, the hysteria that had once haunted my mother well and truly manifested itself in my sister.

Trista smiles and strokes the face that she shares with her sister.

Trista: Do you remember what I said? That my little sister isn't a real actress?

Trista: Well, that's not true. Or rather, not entirely true.

Trista: She is, in a way, the most superb actress and liar I've ever seen.
It's just a pity that she did it so well. No one could recognize her talent.

Trista steps back, melting into the shadow just as she had appeared from it.

Trista: There's another door. You should take a look.

Trista: Go find it. It's right by you. Go on, look for it. I assure you, it's there.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Ordinary Door

CH17701-07

Ordinary Door

After a brief search, you find the door.

A door of distress. There are white candles burning beside it. You hear the whimpering sobs of someone's friends and family.

A door of warmth. There are birds perched on it. They are chirping cheerfully.

You push the door. It opens.

Ring Road

The Dittarsdorf house seems quieter than usual. Those who pass by do so hurriedly, lest some of its misfortune rub off on them.

Kakania: ... Isolde, I'm so, so sorry.

Kakania: If you ever need someone—or anything—I'm right here for you. Call me anytime. The company and support of friends are most important, especially during this time.

Kakania: And if you feel uncomfortable at home, you're more than welcome to stay in my clinic.

She turns back to Isolde, who is standing by the gate.

She is as elegant and upright as always—her body slender, her face pale, her eyes black.

Isolde: Thank you, Ms. Kakania.

Isolde: I ... I'll be fine. You needn't worry about me.

Isolde: ...

After a brief silence, she casts her eyes down.

Isolde: The Dittarsdorf family needs me as a hostess more than ever. My reputation is worthless at the moment.

Isolde: Given the circumstances of his death, Theophil's body isn't suitable to be displayed at a wake.

Isolde: So, Mr. Karl suggested we bury him sooner so he may rest in peace rather than painfully linger in this world.

Isolde: The maids are packing his things. A third of his paintings will be buried with him. As for the financial disputes between himself and his models, they remain to be solved.

Isolde: And I, I ...

She hesitates, looking to the decorated iron gate of the Dittarsdorf house. Its recent neglect has allowed dirt to grow in its crevices.

Isolde: I'm the last living Dittarsdorf, Ms. Kakania. It falls to me to shoulder our burdens.

Isolde: I can't live like this. I can't let my wandering womb control me anymore. The fainting, the convulsions, those visceral disturbances. I will not allow myself to become some horrifying lunatic.

Kakania: Isolde ...

Isolde: I've decided to accept Dr. Schwartz's treatment.

Isolde raises her head and gives Kakania a smile.

Isolde: Times are different now. New treatments are emerging day by day. I'm sure he'll find a way to help me.

Kakania: ...

Kakania: Kakania remains silent. Finally, she lets out a sigh.

Kakania: I really don't think Schwartz is the best doctor for you. You're a Dittarsdorf, for goodness's sake, not some commoner. He's only trying to use your status to gain profit and attention!

Kakania: That's why he insisted the treatment process be open to the public.

Kakania: But, as your friend, I respect your decision. And I completely understand why you'd choose to accept the treatment.

Kakania: Just know that you have the right to stop him at any time. Please, Isolde, as soon as you feel any discomfort—any pain—promise me you'll tell him to stop.

Isolde: Can I do that ...?

Kakania: Every living person has the right to express their discomfort!

Kakania: Hm ... But it's possible that, under the circumstances, you'll be unable to stop him ...

Kakania rubs her chin, immersed in thought. Then her eyes light up.

Kakania: Of course! The presentation is open to all, so I can be there too!

Kakania: I'll sit in the audience and keep a close eye on you. If things get out of control, I'll stop him ...

Kakania's face looks considerably brighter with this idea. Her voice is as clear and colorful as a parrot's.

Isolde listens quietly, chuckling from time to time at Kakania's chattering.

Isolde: Thank you, Ms. Kakania. You're a great friend.

Isolde looks at her, her eyes twinkling. A pink blush rises on her pale cheeks.

She steps closer to Kakania and fixes her collar, as she has done countless times before.

Isolde: By the way, when you were in the house just now, did you notice a door?

Kakania: A door?

Puzzled, her eyes dart from Isolde to the gate and back.

Kakania: What kind of door?

Isolde: Just an ordinary door. There's nothing special about it.

Kakania: Huh?

She blinks in confusion.

Kakania: I don't get it, Isolde. There are many doors throughout your home. Which one are you referring to?

Isolde: Nothing ... Forget it. It's not important.

Having dealt with the collar, Isolde pulls back her hands and steps back behind the gate.

Isolde: It's getting late. You should head home.

Kakania: Oh my, is that the time? You're right, I should go. I have a patient—I mean, a visitor—who requires the help of my "witchcraft"!

Kakania: Thanks for reminding me. Then I shall take my leave ...

Lowering her hat, Kakania leaves with her suitcase in hand. She quickly blends into the crowd.

The maid steps forward and starts to close the huge metal gate.

Isolde: Ms. Kakania, wait!

Isolde's voice sings out above the squeaking of the gate.

She notices the green feathers in Kakania's hat flick in the crowd.

Kakania: Yes? You called me?

Isolde: If Dr. Schwartz's therapy doesn't work, could you please treat me?

Kakania: Of course! You're always welcome!

Now the feathers jiggle cheerfully. Kakania swims against the current, returning to the gate.

Kakania: You're my greatest friend in all Vienna! I'd be more than happy to help!

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Golden Key

CH17701-08

A Golden Key

Isolde: I have a small room. It has a simple door.

Isolde: The room is cramped. It's a truly tiny little room.

Isolde: But besides that simple door, there are many, many other doors in this room. Big ones, small ones; hard ones, soft ones; mushy and wet ones; warm and furry ones.

Isolde: They're in front of me. They're behind me. There are so many of them, and more keep coming. They squeeze me.

Isolde: ...

Isolde: Do you know how that feels? To be squeezed by many, many doors?

Isolde turns her eyes to you.

Isolde: I suppose no one in the world has felt what it's like. No one would ever place so many doors in one room.

Isolde: Door after door lies on me, compressing me until my skin, my flesh, and bones squeak under the pressure. I'm enveloped by endless pain, as if my flesh is being torn from my skeleton.

Isolde: When I was a little girl, I read a story about a princess who tried to sleep on a hundred layers of mattresses yet was still kept awake by a single pea beneath them.

Isolde: My father called her the true embodiment of a princess, a good maiden with noble virtue and the most delicate skin in the world. He said that I should be such a lady, both sensitive and polite.

Isolde: But am I that princess?

Isolde: Or that bothersome little pea under a hundred mattresses?

Evangeline: Baby, my child, my darling ...

Mother hugged me, as she always did when overtaken with despair. Theophil had grown up, and Trista was long gone, so I was her only choice.

The day prior, her hysteria had burst out at a banquet, making her shame all the more potent. That's why she came to my room and held me close.

Evangeline: You must always remember Mama's words. Don't you ever forget!

Evangeline: You have to be careful. Don't allow others to see your vulnerability. Don't cry, don't scream, don't lose control ... Don't make a fool of yourself.

Evangeline: Your true self is filthy. Reveal it, and it will hurt you—even kill you.

Her hands squeezed my arms, quivering. I couldn't help but quiver with her.

Evangeline: It will only make you suffer—keep you from your dreams and plunge you into nightmares ...

Evangeline: It's a most frightful, terrible beast, and it will tear you apart! Just as it tore me, and your grandmother, and your great grandmother.

Evangeline: You must conceal it, Isolde! Not one girl in our cursed family has been able to survive in this world without doing so. You must follow the rules of society.

I didn't fully comprehend what she meant back then. Curses, rules, concealment ... It was all too complicated for a four-year-old child.

So I asked her what it meant, what I should do.

Evangeline: ...

There was a long silence before Mother spoke, so long that I almost fell asleep in her arms.

In my semi-dreamlike state, I heard my mother's voice. It was soft and distant, as if floating down from a cloud.

Evangeline: You must learn to play a "role" in life, my little Isolde ...

She brushed my hair with her fingers, her face twisted in agony.

She had been dancing in this pair of hot iron shoes for over twenty years, and in this moment, she presented them to me.

Evangeline: You must learn to know what people expect from you. Then, do everything you can to meet those expectations.

Evangeline: You'll have to work harder than anyone else to satisfy the people around you so as to make their "tolerance" of you worthwhile ...

Evangeline: Smile despite your suffering and breakdowns, and walk steadily, even if your feet are crippled, even if the road ahead seems fine to others but in ruins to you ...

She cupped my face in her hands, kissing my forehead and cheeks. Her tears fell on my face like rain.

She was in so much pain—for me and for herself. It was terrifying to wear that pair of burning iron shoes like that. But it was the only way our ancestors survived. It was the only way we would survive.

And that was the first time I saw a "door." It was small and blue, just the right size for a child like me to pass through.

It squeezed into my room like a cat squeezes through a crack in a door. Eventually, I fell asleep in my mother's arms.

It was not the door to the small room.

Karl: A hundred times. That's right, scoop up the soup one hundred times.

It was then that I saw the second door.

Karl: You've done well, my child. See? Your hands have stopped shaking.

Mr. Karl stood by that door. His figure was formidable.

I kept my distance. I didn't like Mr. Karl.

I respected him, but I feared him. He seemed so tall to me—grander than a palace, more oppressive than a mountain. He haunted my every nightmare.

In those nightmares, he was an entrance to a wide, luxurious ballroom. It was filled with faceless people, all staring at me silently.

Sometimes I was disheveled, barefoot, or naked. But I was always scrambling to cover myself up—to hide my shame.

It's the door to the Dittarsdorf house, and I am the last remaining Dittarsdorf. It is mine alone. Of course it's in the room.

It isn't the door to the small room, either.

Heinrich: Literature.

Theophil: Art.

Heinrich: Poetry. Stage design.

Theophil: Models. Romance.

...

I've never paid much attention to their conversations, but these words summarize the majority of their topics.

Theophil: Oh? What do you think, Heinrich?

Theophil is an enthusiastic and perhaps "kind-hearted" person.

He understood himself to be a noble man and a brother. I cannot deny that he fulfilled his obligations, nor can I deny his foolishness. He spent his days indulging in his pleasures with blissful decadence.

He brought me gifts, like Mayer's hound brought her its prey.

And his eyes glittered just like the hound's did.

I would thank him and take his gifts, which greatly inspired him to go on the hunt once more.

As I'm sure you can tell, he was easily pleased. We had a simple relationship.

Heinrich: Hey, why don't we start an organization together?

Heinrich: I just thought of an excellent name—

Is Heinrich a friend of mine or my brother? How did we even come to be friends?

Our parents were close. He and Theophil grew up together. We'd spent long holidays on each other's estates since we were children.

How time had flown. That little chatterbox had become taller than I.

His fervor for conversation, although sometimes grating, was not without benefit, however. He introduced me to many new faces.

Klara: That's a superb name! I'd love to join!

It was he who introduced me to her—my new friend.

Playwright: Salome ...

...

What can I say about her?

My mother's therapist, the gardener, and Maggie the maid were all her and her father's moles.

Who picked up the trash bags of old handkerchiefs, worn pajamas, and dirty bed sheets that were left outside the gate? Who ate the dead rabbit that signaled my birth?

Does the answer really matter?

They were quiet, sincere, even. They made no demands, no requests.

Like a pebble lying at the bottom of a river or in the gaps of a railroad, they lived in their own world.

They couldn't even stir up a wave, let alone become the straw that broke the camel's back. They impacted no one.

But still, when Mr. Karl's ballroom pressed upon me, so, too, did she slip into my shoe. A small stone. A perpetual annoyance compounding my great pain.

Playwright: My ... muse ...

It's just as Father said.

"Be generous, my daughter. It is an honor that they love you so much."

"Be lenient. Let them be."

Evangeline: Sleep, my darling, safe and sound ...

This is how her story should end, don't you think?

Evangeline: My darling baby ... Trista, Isolde ...

Evangeline: I keep hearing things ... My heart is broken, my joints are screaming ... no, not my joints, my spleen. It feels as though it's ruptured, and there are a million voices shouting in my head ...

Evangeline: What should I do? What should I do!? You need to help me! No, who can help me?

She was in so much distress—so much pain.

My mother, my Evangeline.

She could no longer hold her baby. She could no longer live in the illusion of a forever young Apfelstrudel and Blume. She was like an overfilled glass of wine that finally spilled over, staining the clothes of everyone at the table.

Evangeline: This is "salvation" ... My dear, dear ...

Evangeline: The world is filthy. Just breathing is torturous ...

When she dreamed about Trista, when she saw that sweet smile again, when she relived her death ...

... Mother found the exit of her life.

The door to freedom opened before her.
And she was far too kind to leave behind her husband and maids.

Evangeline followed Trista. Theophil followed Evangeline.

One in water, one in fire—they ended their lives.

Not only had the curse taken Evangeline, but also the two remaining men of the Dittarsdorf family. The curse that had once only plagued my mother's family had truly taken over all the Dittarsdorfs.

People started looking at me with pitiful and prying eyes. Of course, they would gaze at a tragic but wealthy and well-bred girl like that, especially those who had sons of marriageable age.

Karl: Oh, my poor Isolde. Why is this happening to you?

Karl: First your father, then your mother, and now Theophil ...

Mr. Karl wiped his tears with a white hankie. His face ruddy and full, like a peach. The sincerity of his response made him almost charming.

Was he always this way?
Where was that stern, harsh gentleman from my memory?

I thanked him, I consoled him, and I shook his hand. This was the Karl my father saw, wasn't it?

I was an adult then. He was treating me as such.

Kakania: Isolde ... Are you alright?

Luckily, there were some more welcome visitors.

A different kind of friend. A friend who stood by my side, a sincere worried expression on her face.

Kakania: Call me anytime, no matter how late it is. Don't hesitate, alright?

...

Isolde: By the way, when you were in the house just now, did you notice a door?

Kakania: A door? What kind of door?

Isolde: It's a door. One of the most common types. No one would notice it was placed in such a big, magnificent mansion.

Isolde: It appeared on the evening of my thirteenth birthday.

Isolde: I vomited on my bed that night. I couldn't digest all that cake and roast chicken. My stomach hurt.

Isolde: Those wandering spirits bent over me, making funny faces and silently clapping as I heaved up my dinner.

Isolde: The guests downstairs were waiting for me. I had to get myself together to go back and thank everyone for celebrating my birthday with me.

Isolde: But I was too tired. I hadn't had a good night's sleep in months.

Isolde: And that was when I came up with the idea.

Isolde: I invited the spirits to fall upon me, whether they were willing or not.

Isolde: I utilized the spirits' proficiencies to do what I couldn't do alone. They helped me flatter my guests, behave well, sing and dance, read and write literature ... They aided me in everything.

Isolde: And I was able to rest.

Isolde: I was finally able to rest.

Isolde: ...

Theophil's funeral is over. More than half of the servants have been let go. Ms. Dittasdorf says she needs some time alone and refuses to receive any visitors.

Isolde crosses the living room, walking straight to the sideboard.

Isolde: Maggie isn't home, so there's no one to take care of Blume, Apfelstrudel, and the nightingale and swan ...

She opens the drawer and takes out a metal box of arsenic powder.

It has been the most deadly poison since the time of ancient Rome until today.

Isolde: They're my responsibility now.

Isolde: Here, Apfelstrudel, Blume, come have some ...

She carries the box over to the tea table by the window and places the box on it.

Isolde: Be graceful, be self-restrained, and be kind to others.

She tilts the tea pot and watches the tea flow into the cup.

Isolde: Be compassionate, especially towards the less privileged.

Isolde: There's nothing to be afraid of. You have the right to leave this ruined world ...

Isolde: We ... must be an example for our people.

Isolde: Oh dear, you're twitching ... It's alright. I'll hold you.

Isolde: We must ...

Isolde drops her eyes. The arsenic powder dissolves in the hot tea as if it had never existed.

She raises the tea cup and slightly lowers her head.

Isolde: We must be virtuous and dignified, as befits our status, Theophil.

In the tea cup, her charred brother gazes at her sorrowfully.

Isolde: Ah ... How careless I am. I almost forgot the date today.

She raises her head and throws the tea cup over her shoulder, splashing her brother's face on the floor.

She picks up her coat from the hanger and walks toward the porch, muttering to herself.

Isolde: My new doctor, my Kakania ... Dr. Kakania.

Clinic Doorway

Isolde: Oh, it appears I've arrived a little early.

It is good etiquette for a lady to arrive early to an appointment.

Isolde: That's alright. I can wait. I have patience.

Isolde: Ms. Kakania ... Oh, I suppose I should call her Dr. Kakania from now on.

She looks up at the closed door.

Isolde: There's no sign indicating that this is the consultation room ... Oh, right, she doesn't have a medical license.

Isolde: Ah, so she's painted the door this color so that the patients can tell where she is. How very clever.

As she waits, Isolde murmurs softly to herself.

Isolde: There are so many doors in this world.

Isolde: Is Dr. Kakania a door, too? What kind of door would she be, I wonder?

Isolde: Would it be green or shining like silk? Perhaps ...

She is interrupted by a familiar voice.

Kakania: Hmm? Isolde?

Kakania: Sorry, I'm late!

Kakania trots over to her, her lively green skirt swaying with each step.

Kakania: I was delayed. You know what I'm like. I swear I'd planned to return earlier to ensure this didn't happen! This is our first consultation, after all! Oh, I so wanted to have a good start to our doctor-patient relationship!

Kakania: I'm really, very sorry. Have you been waiting long?

Kakania: Are you tired? Oh, I shouldn't have kept you waiting under the sun ...

As Kakania continues her apologies, she pulls a golden key with a green ribbon from her waist.

A golden key to the golden lock on the door. She inserts it and turns it. The door opens.

Kakania: Alright, come on in! I'll fetch you a cup of tea.

Kakania enters the side room. Isolde can see her cheerful green dress reflected in the corner of the mirror as she busies herself with the tea.

Isolde: I'm looking forward to it.

There she is, reflected in the Vingler's Mirror, the daughter of a mirror seller. Klara. Dr. Kakania.

She's not a door. I was wrong. Very wrong.

She is a key.

The key that will finally unlock my door.

THE END